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My Foot in It

‘This isn’t going to be our day, is it?’

We all knew it was going to happen, although not many of us had ever believed it would. Soon after the manager signed a new contract in 1999, he said it would be his last and that 2001/02 would be his final season with United. His reasons seemed obvious enough: he wanted to relax a little after twenty-odd years as a manager up in Scotland and then at Old Trafford. He wanted to travel. He wanted to see his family. He probably wanted to be able to spend more time at the racecourse. Even before Rock Of Gibraltar made him famous as an owner, we knew he loved horses with the same passion he loved soccer. On one of my last days out with the lads as a United player, the boss took us all over to Chester races. It was a great afternoon. Even though I felt by then, in late April 2003, that I was being pushed to the fringe of things at Old Trafford, the togetherness for those few hours was as good as it had ever been in my time at the club: it was a real United family outing. The gaffer himself was having such a good time, you couldn’t help getting into the spirit of it yourself.

When he’d first told everybody about his plans for retirement, it had seemed something that was a long way in the future. But during 2001 it started being written about and talked about more and more. There were stories about the boss becoming an ambassador for the club, especially out in the Far East. There were reports about disagreements with the board, and the boss saying he was going to cut off all ties with the club. The players didn’t know any more about the speculation than what was in the papers. It wasn’t until what was meant to be his last season had kicked off that it began to sink in, after he sat us down and told us he would be leaving the club the following May. Once we started work, it wasn’t something the players thought about every day or talked about in the dressing room. We didn’t have to. I don’t